

What is positive psychological functioning?

PPF encompasses multiple indicators of psychological well-being and can be characterized as the positive feelings and cognitions of individuals who evaluate their lives favorably and function effectively.

What is flourishing in positive psychology?

"Flourishing is the product of the pursuit and engagement of an authentic life that brings inner joy and happiness through meeting goals, being connected with life passions, and enjoying in accomplishments through the peaks and valleys of life.

Human flourishing: for example, such goods as knowledge, health, friendship, creative achievement, beauty, and pleasure

What are the views of positive psychology on human beings?

What is positive psychology psychological perspective?

Positive psychology theory focuses on the positive aspects of human life, such as happiness, strengths, and fulfillment, rather than solely on pathology and mental illness. As such, it offers therapists a unique perspective and toolset for helping their clients improve their mental health and overall wellbeing.

A Take-Home Message

When Martin Seligman became president of the American Psychological Association (APA), he changed the focus of psychology from what was wrong in our lives to how to flourish (Seligman, 2011).

As a therapist, including positive psychology into your practice can benefit your clients by helping them to identify and build upon their strengths, set and achieve meaningful goals, and increase their overall wellbeing. It can also enhance your personal fulfillment and satisfaction as a mental health professional by

providing a more holistic and proactive approach to mental health care.

Positive psychology interventions are effective in reducing depression, increasing life satisfaction, and enhancing coping skills. Incorporating positive psychology into your practice can help clients build resilience, cultivate gratitude, and find meaning and purpose.

How does positive psychology affect human function?

Positive psychology's main aim is to encourage people to discover and nurture their character strengths, rather than channeling their efforts into correcting shortcomings. Positive psychology highlights the need for one to shift their negative outlook to a more optimistic view in order to improve quality of life.

Overview of Positive Psychology

Introduction

In today's world, society is facing extremely tough challenges in the form of global warming, natural disasters, economic recession, homelessness, terrorism and the continuation of war. With all this sadness and horror, where in the world does a science based on testing happiness, wellbeing, personal growth and 'the good life' fit into the modern-day agenda?

This chapter will take you through the new science of positive psychology, which aims to 'understand, test, discover and promote the factors that allow individuals and communities to thrive' (Sheldon et al., 2000).

Positive psychology focuses on wellbeing, happiness, flow, personal strengths, wisdom, creativity, imagination and characteristics of positive groups and institutions.

Furthermore, the focus is not just on how to make individuals happy, but on happiness and flourishing at a group level as well.

We will look at how individuals and groups thrive and how increasing the wellbeing of one will have a positive effect on the other, leading to a win-win situation.

The area of positive psychology is focused on what makes individuals and communities flourish, rather than languish.

Flourishing is defined as 'a state of positive mental health; to thrive, to prosper and free of mental illness, filled with emotional energy and function positively in private and social realms' (Michalec et al., 2009: 391). Indeed, existing figures show that only 18 per cent of adults meet the criteria of flourishing, 65 per cent are moderately mentally healthy and 17 per cent are languishing. Unsurprisingly, flourishing has several positive correlates such as academic achievement, mastery goal setting, higher levels of self-control and continued perseverance (Howell, 2009).

Thus, a science that focuses on the development and facilitation of flourishing environments and individuals is an important addition to the psychological sciences.

Positive psychology concentrates on positive experiences at three time points:

- (1) the **past**, centering on wellbeing, contentment and satisfaction;
- (2) the **present**, which focuses on concepts such as happiness and flow experiences;
- (3) the **future**, with concepts including optimism and hope.

Not only does positive psychology distinguish between wellbeing across time points but it also separates the subject area into three nodes:

- the **subjective** node, which encompasses things like positive experiences and states across past, present and future (for example, happiness, optimism, wellbeing);
- the **individual** node, which focuses on characteristics of the 'good person' (for example, talent, wisdom, love, courage, creativity); and
- the **group** node, which studies positive institutions, citizenship and communities (for example, altruism, tolerance, work ethic) (Positive Psychology Center, 1998).

Contrary to criticism, positive psychology is not a selfish psychology. At its best, positive psychology has been able to give the scientific community, society and individuals a new perspective on existing ideas as well as providing empirical evidence to support the phenomenon of human flourishing.

Above all, though, positive psychology has challenged and rebalanced the deficit approach to living while connecting its findings to many different disciplines. Throughout this textbook you will see how inducing positive emotions, committing acts of kindness and enhancing social connections enable individual and societal flourishing, demonstrating the usefulness of the discipline for individual, group and community wellbeing.

Positive psychology reorients psychological research and practice from psychopathology to well-being (Seligman, 2019) "from "What is wrong?" to "What works, what is right, and what is improving?" (Sheldon & King, 2001, p. 216).

Positive psychology has been described in many ways and with many words, but the commonly accepted definition of the field is this: "Positive psychology is the scientific study of what makes life most worth living" (Peterson, 2008). To push this brief description a bit further, positive psychology is a scientific approach to

studying human thoughts, feelings, and behavior, with a focus on strengths instead of weaknesses, building the good in life instead of repairing the bad, and taking the lives of average people up to “great” instead of focusing solely on moving those who are struggling up to “normal”

Definition:

Martin Seligman & Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi define positive psychology as —the scientific study of positive human functioning and flourishing on multiple levels that include the biological, personal, relational, institutional, cultural, and global dimensions of life.

Sheldon and King (2001) define positive psychology as “nothing more than the scientific study of ordinary human strengths and virtues (goodness/qualities)”

Gable and Haidt (2005) defined positive psychology is “the study of the conditions and processes that contribute to the flourishing or optimal functioning of people, groups and institutions.”

“Positive psychology is the scientific study of what makes life most worth living” (Peterson, 2008)

According to American Psychological Association (APA), Positive Psychology is a field of psychological theory and research that focuses on the psychological states (e.g., contentment, joy), individual traits or character strengths (e.g., intimacy, integrity, altruism, wisdom), and social institutions that enhance subjective well-being and make life most worth living.

“Positive Psychology is the side of the science of human mind and behavior that studies and promotes the best of humanity.” It has always been part of psychological science, but modern life has heightened the need to give special attention specifically to the positive aspects of psychology. Positive psychology is the positive half of psychological science. As such, it will end up as composing half of almost every chapter in an Introductory Psychology textbook.

Positive psychology, which is the scientific and applied approach to uncovering people’s strengths and promoting their positive functioning. (See the article “Building Human Strength,” in which positive psychology pioneer Martin Seligman gives his views about the need for this new field.) Although other subareas of psychology were not focused on human weaknesses, twentieth-century applied psychology and psychiatry typically were. For example, consider the statement attributed to Sigmund Freud that the goal of psychology should be “to replace neurotic misery with ordinary unhappiness” (cited in Simonton & Baumeister, 2005, p. 99). Thus, the applied psychology of yesteryear was mostly about mental illness and understanding and helping the people who were living such tragedies.

Positive psychology, on the other hand, offers a balance to this previous weakness-oriented approach by suggesting that we also must explore people’s strengths along with their weaknesses. In advocating this focus on strengths, however, in no way do we mean to lessen the importance and pain associated with human suffering.

What is Positive Psychology?

Positive psychology is the scientific and practical pursuit of optimal human functioning and it augments psychology’s long-

term focus on weakness and illness. Positive psychology efforts underway to shift focus from preoccupation only with repairing the worst things in life to also building positive qualities while traditional focus in psychology has been on pathology

Asks fundamental questions:

- What kinds of families result in children who flourish?
- What work settings support the greatest satisfaction among workers?
- What policies result in the strongest civic engagement?
- How can people's lives be most worth living?

Dimensions of Positive Psychology/ Three levels of positive psychology

Positive psychology isn't limited to feeling a sense of individual well-being itself, rather proponents of this science often refer to the "Three Levels of Positive Psychology"

The range of possible interest areas in positive psychology is quite large; however, some broad dimensions have been used to define the new area in general way. In order to nurture talent and make life more fulfilling, positive psychology focuses on three areas of human experience that help to define the scope and orientation of a positive psychology perspective.

Subjective level

At the subjective level, positive psychology looks at positive subjective states or positive feeling/emotions such as happiness, joy, satisfaction with life, relaxation, love intimacy, and contentment. Positive subjective states also can include constructive thoughts about the self and the future, such as optimism and hope. Positive subjective states may also include feelings of energy, vitality, and confidence, or the effects of positive emotions such as laughter.

Individual Level

At the individual level, positive psychology focuses on a study of positive individual traits, or the more enduring and persistent behavior patterns seen in people over time. This study might include individual traits such as courage, persistence, honesty, or wisdom. That is, positive psychology includes the study of positive behaviors and traits that historically have been used to define “character strengths” or virtues. It can also include the ability to develop aesthetic sensibility or tap into creative potentials and the drive to pursue excellence.

Society/Group Level

At the group or societal level, positive psychology focuses on positive interaction with your community and the development, creation, and maintenance of positive institutions. In this area, positive psychology addresses issues such as the development of civic virtues (goodness), the creation of healthy families, the study of healthy work environments, and positive communities.

Seligman’s (2003) three pillars of positive psychology

1. Positive subjective experiences (such as joy, happiness, contentment, optimism, and hope)
2. Positive individual characteristics (such as personal strengths and human virtues that promote mental health);
3. Positive social institutions and communities that contribute to individual health and happiness.

Psychology’s Forgotten Mission

Psychology has not always focused on the adaptable, the healthy, and the positive aspects of humanity. In fact, for many years professional psychology largely ignored the study of the positive

side of human behavior. Seligman (2000) noted that prior to World War II there were only three major missions in psychology:

- The **first** early mission of psychology was to cure mental illness. The terrible consequences of mental illness for many people, their families, and the community demanded that psychology use the methods of science to seek solutions to this problem.
- The **second** early mission of psychology was to find and nurture genius and talent. Many of the early studies in this area focused on the development of intelligence.
- The **third** early mission of psychology was to make normal life more fulfilling. Obviously, there is more to living a satisfied and happy life than simply getting one's immediate needs met in a reasonable amount of time.

Treating mental illness aspect was remarkably successful, in the early 1950s, however no real cures existed for mental illness. Human beings were perceived as passive creatures in face of childhood repressed impulses, environmental influences or genetic factors. Psychologists started curing damaged brains, damaged childhood, damaged habits, damaged drives. Face of Psychology changed after War and last two missions were forgotten.

References Snyder, C.R., & Lopez, S.J. (2007). Positive Psychology. London: Sage Publications (pp. 3-7) Snyder, C.R., & Lopez, S.J. (2003). Handbook of Positive Psychology. London: Sage Publications (pp. 3-6)

Positive Psychology Seeks a Balanced, More Complete Positive Psychology Seeks a Balanced, More Complete View of Human Functioning

Seeing only the good in one's own actions and the bad in others is a common human foible. Validating only the positive or negative aspects of experience is not productive. It is very tempting to focus on just the good (or the bad) in the world, but it is not good science, and we must not make this mistake in advancing positive psychology.

Although we do not agree with the tenets of the previous pathology models, it would be inaccurate to describe their proponents as being poor scholars, poor scientists, poor practitioners, or bad people. Instead, this previous paradigm was advanced by well-meaning, bright people who were responding to the particular circumstances of their times. Likewise, it is not as if these people were wrong in their depictions of people. They developed diagnoses and measurement approaches for schizophrenia, depression, and alcoholism and validated many effective treatments for specific problems such as panic disorder and blood and injury phobia (see Seligman, *What You Can Change and What You Can't*, 1994).

Thus, those operating within the pathology model were quite accurate in their descriptions of some people at some particular times in their lives. Moreover, they were able to help certain people with select problems. Nevertheless, advocates of the pathology approach were incomplete in their portrayals of humankind. Undeniably, the negative is part of humankind, but only a part, and what is viewed as negative in one group may be positive in another. In addition, a bias toward Western culture is found, thus doubly pathologizing non-dominant groups. Positive psychology offers a look at the other side—that which is good and strong within a cultural context, along with normative ways to nurture and sustain these assets and resources.

Although we explore the positive, we emphasize that this half is no more the entire story than is the negative side. Future psychologists must develop an inclusive approach that examines

both the weaknesses and the strengths of people in varying cultural groups, as well as the stressors and the resources in the environment. That approach would be the most comprehensive and valid.

We have not reached that point, however, because we have yet to develop and explore fully the science and practice of positive psychology. Only when we have done such detective work on the strengths of people within their cultural contexts and the many resources of positive environments will we truly be able to understand all human beings in a more balanced fashion. Our task in these pages, therefore, is to share with you what we do know about positive psychology at this relatively early point in its development.

We look forward to that future time in the field of psychology when the positive is as likely as the negative to be used in assessing people and helping them to lead more satisfying and culturally comfortable existences. That time will probably come during the lifetimes of the readers of this book; some of you may pursue careers in psychology in which you routinely will consider people's strengths along with their weaknesses. Indeed, we feel strongly that your generation will be the one to implement a culturally competent psychology that truly balances the tenets of a positive approach with those of the previous pathology orientation. We also hope that today's parents will use positive psychology techniques to shore up families and bring out the best in their children. Likewise, we imagine a time when school-age children and youth are valued as much for their major strengths as for their scores on state tests or college entrance examinations.

You, the readers, are the stewards of the eventual culturally competent and balanced positive-negative psychology. We warn you about the debate that is already in progress as to the

superiority of one approach over the other. In the next section, we attempt to inoculate you against such “us versus them” thinking.

Assumptions of Positive Psychology:

A major assumption of positive psychology is that the field of psychology has become unbalanced. (Simonton & Baumeister, 2005).

Human goodness and excellence are as authentic as disorders and distress and therefore deserve equal attention from mental health practitioners. Its time to challenge the disease model (Maddux, 2002)

Human beings have the potential for good and that we are motivated to pursue a good life (Linley & Joseph, 2006)

The most basic assumption of positive psychology is that human goodness and excellence are as authentic as disorders and distress and therefore deserve equal attention from mental health practitioners.

The discipline of positive psychology is primarily focused on the promotion of the good life. The good life refers to those factors that contribute most predominately to a well lived life. Qualities that define the good life are those that enrich our lives, make life worth living and foster strong character (Compton, 2005).

Seligman (2002) defines good life as a combination of three elements: Positive connection to others or positive subjective experience; Positive individual traits and; Life regulation qualities.

Positive connection refers to aspects of our behaviour that contribute to positive connectedness to others. It is the positive subjective experiences that includes the ability to love, forgive, and the presence of spiritual connections, happiness and life satisfaction that combine to help and create a sense of deeper meaning and purpose in life.

Positive individual traits may include such things as a sense of integrity, the ability to be creative, and the presence of virtues such as courage and humility.

Life regulation qualities are those qualities that allow us to regulate our day to day behaviour in such a way that we can accomplish our goals. Some of these qualities include a sense of individuality or autonomy, a high degree of a healthy self-control and wisdom to guide behaviour. According to positive psychology, the good life must also include the relationship with other people and the society as a whole (Park & Peterson, 2008; Duckworth, Steen & Seligman, 2005).

A primary goal of what could be termed as the positive psychology movement is to be a promoter for change in the focus of psychology from a preoccupation with repairing the worst things in life to also building positive qualities (Joseph & Linley, 2006). This is especially relevant to the therapeutic context, since positive psychologists would argue that the role of the therapist is not to simply alleviate distress and leave the person free from symptomatology, but also to facilitate wellbeing and fulfillment which is not only a worthwhile goal in its own right, it also serves as a preventive function that buffers against future psychopathology and even recovery from illness (Joseph & Linley, 2006).

Goals of Positive Psychology:

According to Martin Seligman's goal of positive psychology was

- To refocusing the entire field of psychology.
- To find elements of positive psychology represented in so many different areas of psychology, from physiological to clinical psychology.
- To restore balance within the discipline of Psychology which was too much focused on negative aspects.

- To catalyze a change in psychology from a preoccupation only with repairing the worst things in life to also building the best qualities in life.
- To improve understanding of positive human behaviors to balance the negative focus of much mainstream research & theory (Sheldon & King, 2001).
- To develop an empirically-based conceptual understanding and language for describing healthy human functioning that parallels our classification and understanding of mental illness (Keyes, 2003)
- To boost present well being.
- To prevent future problems.
- To make life worthwhile.

